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RACING AHEAD Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Katra Vande Bharat Express passing from Ludhiana, Oct. 2019

1957
A track from **Rajkharsawan to Dangoaposi** (in present-day Jharkhand) is electrified. Subsequently, fully electrified trains also run on this track

1962
Trams are discontinued in Delhi

1969
First superfast train, **Rajdhani Express**, between Howrah and New Delhi, is flagged off

1971-80
IR's progress is halted due to the Indo-Pak war, political instability etc. The stress is on the timely arrival of trains during Emergency. **'Two-inch foams'** are added to second-class berths

1984
The country gets its first mass rapid transit line with **Calcutta Metro**—the track between Esplanade and Bhowanipur starts

1988
Delhi-Mumbai route is electrified, followed by Delhi-Chennai. **The first Shatabdi** runs between New Delhi and Jhansi, and is later extended to Bhopal

1996
Computerised reservation system starts in New Delhi, Mumbai, and Chennai

2002
IR starts **online ticketing** and reservation system. Delhi Metro starts operations

2006
Private players are allowed to operate freight movement. The **Dedicated Freight Corridor** project is announced, which would take more than a decade to take off

2009
IR's revenue surplus reaches a record low of Rs 75 lakh, but still **fares are not raised**. This puts pressure on financial performance and several projects go slow

2012
Railways minister **Dinesh Trivedi loses job** after announcing the first hike in fares in eight years

2015
The **Bibek Debroy panel** for major projects and restructuring of the ministry and the Railway Board lay down a detailed roadmap of reforms

First of the recommendations is followed and IR starts exploring **extra-budgetary borrowings**. It lines up Rs 1 lakh crore from LIC as debt

Dedicated Freight Corridor is revived; 70 per cent of it is commissioned; the rest is expected next year

2016
Gatimaan Express (India's fastest train) makes its maiden journey from Delhi to Agra

2017
GE delivers the first privately manufactured made-in-India locomotive. IR decides to **cut diesel consumption** drastically and move to electricity

2018
French company Alstom delivers **electric locomotives**

2019
Vande Bharat, the country's semi-high speed train, is launched

2022
13,523 trains ferry over **23 million people,** transport 3.89 metric tonnes of freight daily. There are 7,325 stations. IR has 2,93,077 freight wagons, and 76,608 coaches and 12,729 locomotives

cheapest in the world and also impacts the financial health of the public transporter and its capacity to upgrade the facilities. It seeks private investments in operations, whereas players are constantly demanding a regulator and a level playing field.

Still, there is light at the end of the tunnel. India is gradually moving towards semi-high speed trains—from coal-fired steam engines to diesel engines and now electric ones. But the railways' core issues lie in seeking reforms to pull itself out of the socialist era and make investments possible.

The agenda for the next 25 years is clear—a level playing field for private players and matching global standards of rail journey. ■